initiative would be “stillborn.”[244] These commitments included support to Pakistan, which was “exceptionally close” to China.[245] Thus, while deferring any decision on economic assistance or debt relief to India until after the China trip, Kissinger told an interagency group the president wanted to be “forthcoming” when it came to Pakistan. He also wanted to find a way to restore “some degree of military assistance” to Pakistan.[246]

The administration also assured China that it would keep it updated on US regional policy. Kissinger sent a message to Zhou that the US would not make any South Asia policy changes without consulting Beijing. The administration intended to follow there “an approach which parallels that of the People’s Republic of China.”[247]

During the visit to China, Nixon repeated this assurance to Zhou, indicating that he would keep Beijing informed of US policy in the subcontinent because “your interest here is greater than ours.” Furthermore, he indicated “it is essential to carry out the Prime Minister’s philosophy which is also ours, that no nation should establish dominance in that part of the subcontinent”—a statement that Indian policymakers, had they known about it, would likely have interpreted as evidence of Sino-US collusion to contain India.

Nixon also claimed credit for Moscow restraining India and for saving West Pakistan during the war. He told Mao and Zhou that he had held steadfast despite the domestic political costs and bureaucratic opposition in the US. Nixon also assured Zhou that, while it might be difficult for domestic political reasons for the US to aid Pakistan militarily, it would provide substantial economic assistance—freeing up Pakistani resources to acquire military supplies from others.

Just as Soviet leaders had played up Sino-US collaboration in order to promote closer India-Soviet ties, Nixon sought to play up India-Soviet collusion to encourage greater Sino-US collaboration. The president told Zhou that India alone was hardly a threat to China, but an India backed by the Soviet Union was a “present threat”—one against whom China had limited options. Nixon assured the premier that the US would use its “influence to prevent Japanese or Indian attacks against China.” Furthermore, Washington would say nothing about those two countries that could embarrass China.[248]